

CookieDrop Vending

\$20k a month from a single cookie machine in an airport — no staff, no rent, runs 24/7.

What It Is

An automated cookie vending business. Instead of opening bakeries, you place smart vending machines that dispense fresh, heat-sealed packaged cookies in captive high-traffic spots — airports, train stations, hospitals, malls, and universities. Customers tap the screen, pay, and get a travel-ready cookie box in seconds. You're selling convenience and access in places where people can't say no.

How It Makes Money

Pure unit margin on every box, around the clock, with no employees. Revenue scales by adding machines in more captive locations once one proves out. Add-ons: branded/co-branded cookie boxes, seasonal flavors, and B2B placements where venues take a small revenue share for the floor space.

Startup Costs

- Smart packaged-goods vending machine (Alibaba: "smart vending machine touchscreen" / "automatic cookie vending machine"): \$3,500–\$9,000 per unit
- Shipping + import duty: \$400–\$1,200
- Cookie supply (baked + heat-sealed by you or a co-packer): \$1.50–\$2.50 per box landed
- Heat-sealer + packaging (or co-packer fee): \$300–\$1,500
- LLC, insurance, food permits: \$500–\$1,500
- Premium location lease/rev-share (airport spots cost more): \$500–\$2,500/mo
- Branding/wrap + signage: \$300–\$700
- **Total to launch (first machine): \$6,000–\$16,000** (airport placements run higher)

The Numbers

- Cost per cookie box (make + seal + packaging): ~\$2.00
- Sell price: \$6–\$8
- Profit per box: \$4.00–\$6.00
- A captive-location machine sells ~100–140 boxes/day
- 120 boxes/day x \$5 profit x 30 = **~\$18,000/month profit per machine** (before premium rent)
- After a \$1,500/mo airport rev-share, still ~\$16,000 net. Add machines in 2–3 more transit hubs to scale past \$40k/month.

How To Start

1. Order one smart vending machine; confirm refrigeration (if needed), card payments, and remote telemetry.
2. Lock your cookie supply — bake and heat-seal yourself, or contract a local co-packer for consistency and shelf life.
3. Form an LLC and get the food permits required for vended packaged food in your area.
4. Negotiate a placement in a high-traffic captive location (airport concessions, hospital, university — start with whichever you can access).

5. Wrap the machine in appetizing branding and load 4–6 best-selling flavors.
6. Track sales remotely, restock on a schedule, and watch which flavors and times sell.
7. Reinvest profits into machines 2 and 3 in similar captive, high-dwell-time locations.

Where To Get Customers

Captive foot traffic is the customer — secure placements in airports, train/bus stations, hospitals, universities, malls, office towers, and gyms. Deal directly with concession managers, facility operators, and property managers; offer a rev-share to win prime spots.

Pro Tips

- Captive locations beat busy ones — travelers and patients with time to kill and few options convert far better than a crowded street.
- Heat-seal for shelf life and a "travel-ready" pitch; cookies that survive a flight let you sell in spots fresh bakeries can't.
- Airport/hospital placement contracts are the moat — they're hard to get, so once you land one, lock a multi-machine or exclusivity term.